

Adversarial Brief: The Case Against AARO

*An evidence-tagged skeptical investigation of the U.S. All-domain Anomaly Resolution Office. Each major claim is tagged by evidentiary strength: **[STRONG]** = primary documents, congressional record, or on-the-record named officials; **[MODERATE]** = credible journalism or reasoned inference from documented facts; **[WEAK]** = advocacy framing, contested accounts, or enthusiast-sourced claims.*

TL;DR

- **The strongest, best-evidenced case against AARO is structural and procedural, not proof of a "honeypot."** AARO is a subordinate Pentagon/Intelligence Community office that was asked to investigate its own chain of command; its first director was a 27-year intelligence insider rather than a neutral investigator; its flagship 2024 Historical Record Report rested on roughly 30 interviews, contained basic factual errors, was not endorsed by the Director of National Intelligence, and was pre-briefed only to hand-picked outlets;

and several key witnesses did not trust it. These critiques hold up under scrutiny.

- **The "captured / conflict-of-interest" critique is well-supported** — even AARO's sympathizers concede "a subordinate DoD or IC office finding its superiors innocent" was never going to be credible. **The deliberate "honeypot / disinformation vehicle" thesis is plausible and argued by serious people, but rests largely on historical analogy and inference, and is structurally close to unfalsifiable.**
- **Congress itself has acted on distrust of AARO** — the gutted UAP Disclosure Act, a statutorily mandated GAO review of AARO, special-access-program funding limits, and on-the-record doubts from senators on the Intelligence Committee — which is the most authoritative available evidence that AARO's own overseers do not consider it sufficient or fully credible.

Key Findings

1. AARO reports through the Office of the Under Secretary of Defense for Intelligence and Security (OUSD(I&S)) — the very chain of command accused of concealing programs — a conflict of interest acknowledged even by AARO-sympathetic critics. **[STRONG]**

2. First director Sean Kirkpatrick was a career DIA/CIA/IC officer; critics argue a subordinate official clearing his own superiors was never a neutral arbiter. **[STRONG]**
3. The Historical Record Report Vol. 1 conducted ~30 interviews, contained multiple factual errors, was not signed off by the DNI, and was pre-briefed only to select outlets. **[STRONG]**
4. The report's central "circular reporting" finding names no individuals and does not adjudicate named witnesses' specific claims. **[STRONG]**
5. The Grusch–AARO dispute is genuinely two-sided: FOIA documents show AARO repeatedly invited Grusch and he declined; Grusch says AARO never resolved his security concerns and cannot access what he gave the ICIG. **[STRONG]**
6. Members of Congress across both chambers and parties (Mace, Burchett, Luna, Burlison; Senators Rubio, Gillibrand, Rounds, Schumer) have publicly doubted AARO's candor. **[STRONG]**
7. Congress's legislative actions (watered-down UAP Disclosure Act, mandated GAO review, SAP funding limits) constitute institutional distrust of AARO. **[STRONG]**
8. The deliberate-disinformation / "limited hangout" reading is supported by precedent (Robertson Panel, Condon Report) and process irregularities but not by direct evidence. **[MODERATE / WEAK]**

Details

1. Critiques of Effectiveness

The Historical Record Report Vol. 1 (March 8, 2024).

AARO's flagship congressionally mandated deliverable concluded it found "no empirical evidence" of extraterrestrial technology [Wikipedia](#) and that crash-retrieval claims are "in large part, the result of circular reporting from a group of individuals who believe this to be the case, despite the lack of any evidence." [Defense](#) Critics attacked it on multiple fronts:

- **Thin interview base. [STRONG]** By its own text, AARO "reviewed all official USG investigatory efforts since 1945, researched classified and unclassified archives, conducted approximately 30 interviews" [AARO Defense](#) — roughly 30 interviews to cover 80 years (AARO Historical Record Report Vol. I, March 8, 2024, p. 7). Acting director Tim Phillips stressed interviewees "had incomplete or unauthorized access" [Metabunk](#) and "sincerely misinterpreted real events or mistaken sensitive U.S. programs...as having been related to UAP."
- **Factual errors. [STRONG]** Per The Debrief (March 14, 2024), the report placed Kenneth Arnold's seminal 1947 sighting on the wrong date;

asserted the late Senator Harry Reid "had been from New Mexico, rather than his actual home state of Nevada"; [The Debrief](#) referred to the Battelle statistical analysis (Special Report No. 14) as "Project BEAR" (a nickname, not the program name); and misnamed Project Blue Book director Lt. Col. Robert Jones Friend "Roger J. Friend." These appear in the most consequential modern government UAP document.

- **The Battelle/STORK misrepresentation.** **[STRONG]** Per Marik von Rennenkampff (The Hill, March 15, 2024), AARO claimed "all cases that had enough data were resolved and explainable," [The Hill](#) but the Battelle study in fact found that "of the UFO cases considered 'Excellent' and with sufficient data to draw a conclusion, 33 percent were categorized as having 'unknown' origin."
- **No DNI endorsement.** **[STRONG]** Mellon notes: "this appears to be the first AARO report submitted to Congress that the Director of National Intelligence (DNI) did not sign off on. I don't know why, but Avril Haines and her Office were quite right not to in this case." [The Debrief](#)
- **Process irregularities.** **[STRONG]** DoD Public Affairs held a closed-door, invitation-only pre-brief for a select group of outlets, excluding UAP-focused outlets such as The Debrief; the

participating outlets then "uncritically parroted the report's findings." [The Debrief](#)

- **Mellon's verdict. [STRONG]** Christopher Mellon, former Deputy Assistant Secretary of Defense for Intelligence, wrote in his ~16,000-word analysis (The Debrief, April 2024): "this is the most error-ridden and unsatisfactory government report I can recall reading during or after decades of government service... Were I reviewing this as a graduate student's thesis it would receive a failing grade for failing to understand the assignment, sloppy and inadequate research, and flawed interpretation of the data." [The Debrief](#) [thedebrief](#)

The mandate-mismatch critique. [MODERATE] Mellon argues the statute required a history of UAP "relating to unidentified anomalous phenomena," but AARO instead delivered "a summary history of the records of flawed USG investigations of UAP" [thedebrief](#) — sidestepping the phenomena themselves.

The "GoFast" analytic failure. [MODERATE] Von Rennenkampff (The Hill, Dec. 2024) notes that under new director Jon Kosloski, AARO's resolution of the well-known "GoFast" video failed to interview the aircrew and missed that the object was one of several flying in formation — "a major analytic oversight." [The Hill](#)

Data-gap and infrastructure critiques. [MODERATE]

Mellon's November 2024 submission to the House Oversight Committee ("Addressing the UAP Data Gap") argued advanced US sensor data on UAP has historically not reached AARO, Congress, or scientists, and that he was later "denied by AARO" access to a fast-moving-UAP satellite-imagery report he had previously seen. AARO's "Gremlin" sensor prototype was, as of the late-2024 briefing, deployed at only a single site for a 90-day test — a thin operational footprint relative to AARO's data-collection promises.

2. Conflict of Interest / Capture Arguments

The structural problem. [STRONG] AARO reports through OUSD(I&S) and jointly to DoD/IC leadership (AAROEXEC). Even Mellon — who supports AARO's underlying mission — concedes the core defect: "a subordinate DoD or IC office finding its superiors innocent was never going to satisfy the critics," [thedebrief](#) and "a disruptive secret of that colossal magnitude...would never be revealed in a report to Congress from a mid-level official." Von Rennenkampff frames it bluntly as "a classic conflict of interest in the executive branch investigating itself." [The Hill](#)

Kirkpatrick's background. [STRONG] Kirkpatrick had a 27-year DoD/IC career: a CIA posting, Defense Intelligence Officer for Scientific and Technical

Intelligence at DIA, Deputy Director of Intelligence at STRATCOM and SPACECOM, a stint at the NSC, and chief scientist at DIA's Missile and Space Intelligence Center before leading AARO. Critics argue this made him an institutional insider, not a neutral investigator. He has been quoted telling a 2022 audience: "As an intelligence officer, I would expect all of you to expect me to lie to you." [Muck Rack](#)

The Kona Blue circularity. [MODERATE] AARO's central "debunking" was that named reverse-engineering programs either don't exist, were misidentified authentic programs, or resolved to "Kona Blue" — a never-approved DHS prospective special access program (an offshoot of the canceled AAWSAP/AATIP effort). Journalist George Knapp highlights the logical problem: "No witness who spoke to AARO could possibly have confused what they saw with their own eyes with anything associated with Kona Blue since, after all, Kona Blue never existed. It never had a budget, never had a building, never had any crashed-saucer debris."

Authority/clearance limits. [MODERATE] AARO asserts that under the FY2023 NDAA it "may receive all UAP-related information...regardless of any restrictive access controls, special access programs, or compartmented access programs." [AARO](#) But it operates under Title 10 authorities, and in an April 2023 briefing Sen. Gillibrand and Kirkpatrick

discussed whether Title 10 was adequate or additional authorities were needed. [Metabunk](#) The critical distinction: a statutory right to *receive* voluntarily reported information is not the same as the power to *compel* read-in access to a special access program AARO has not been indoctrinated into. SAP access is program-specific authorization layered atop a clearance, [berrylegal](#) granted at the discretion of each program's access-approval authority — meaning the programs themselves can, in practice, gatekeep.

3. Honeypot / Disinformation / Limited-Hangout Arguments

Named officials calling AARO a cover-up or not credible:

- **Rep. Nancy Mace (R-SC) [STRONG]:** At the Nov. 13, 2024 hearing, AARO "is unable, or perhaps unwilling, to bring forward the truth about the government's activities concerning UAPs. I'm disturbed that AARO itself lacks transparency — even its budget is kept from the public. So if there is no 'there' there, then why are we spending money on it?" She separately told The Washington Times she knows AARO's classified budget and it is "a pretty steep number."
- **Rep. Tim Burchett (R-TN) [STRONG]:** suggested the Pentagon "deliberately sends people with

incomplete knowledge" to brief lawmakers and that the report is a cover-up.

- **Rep. Anna Paulina Luna (R-FL) [STRONG]:** in her hearing opening statement said of Kirkpatrick, "he is a documented liar and brings into question what his purpose at AARO really was if it was not to follow up on investigations and disclose his findings to Members of Congress." [House Oversight Committee](#)
- **Rep. Eric Burlison (R-Mo.) [MODERATE]:** has pushed to put AARO and whistleblowers together in a SCIF "and let's see where the truth really is," [DefenseScoop](#) and pointed to FFRDCs (RAND, MITRE, MIT Lincoln Labs) as holding material outside normal oversight.
- **Luis Elizondo [STRONG]:** "what he was saying is not consistent with the truth... when someone like that blatantly tells you something that is not true, you've got a serious credibility problem."
- **Christopher Mellon [STRONG]:** said he personally introduced Kirkpatrick to firsthand-knowledge witnesses (Elizondo, Eric Davis, Hal Puthoff), directly contradicting Kirkpatrick's "no firsthand witnesses" framing.

The historical analogy. [MODERATE] Critics draw a direct line from AARO to the 1953 CIA-convened Robertson Panel, which recommended a media "debunking" campaign to reduce public interest in

UFOs, and the 1968–69 Condon Report, widely criticized as a predetermined debunking exercise that ended Project Blue Book. Scholarly critics (Michael Swords, David Saunders) argued the Robertson Panel was "elaborate theater" with "pre-ordained" conclusions that "only looked at evidence in the public domain, not higher-quality classified military evidence." The New Paradigm Institute argues AARO's selective journalist pre-briefing replicates this narrative-priming pattern. This is the strongest historical foundation for the "PR exercise" reading — but it is analogy, not direct evidence about AARO's intent.

Kirkpatrick's departure and aftermath.

[STRONG/MODERATE] Kirkpatrick left December 1, 2023, amid whistleblower complaints of an "atmosphere of disinterest" in the office (he says the timing was always planned and that he "accomplished everything I said I was going to do"). [Unknowncountry](#) He joined Oak Ridge National Laboratory and then published a combative Scientific American op-ed and gave interviews attacking "conspiracy-minded" claimants — including a characterization of the disclosure movement as "a self-licking ice cream cone." Critics cite this advocacy posture as evidence he was not a disinterested fact-finder.

4. Specific Controversies

The Grusch dispute (genuinely contested). [STRONG, both sides] FOIA-released AARO memoranda show Kirkpatrick repeatedly invited David Grusch for an oral-history interview; a meeting was scheduled for Nov. 14, 2023, and Grusch failed to appear; AARO provided him memos from the DoD Special Access Program Central Office and the ODNI Controlled Access Programs Office asserting AARO was authorized to receive his information; AARO concluded "it became evident that Mr. Grusch had no intention of providing AARO with information." Grusch counters that AARO first officially contacted him only in November 2023, that his security concerns about non-UAP compartmented programs, NSC SAPs, and CIA Directorate of Operations human-intelligence programs were never answered, and — critically — that "AARO does not have access to the information I provided to the Intelligence Community Inspector General (ICIG) and the Congressional Intelligence Committees under the PPD-19 whistleblowing process." [NewsNation](#) Grusch's ICIG complaint, filed via attorney in May 2022, was deemed "credible and urgent" in July 2022 and forwarded to the congressional intelligence committees. (Separately, lawmakers were told Grusch lacked the active SCIF clearance to discuss specifics after the July 2023 hearing.)

The UAP Disclosure Act (2023). [STRONG] The Schumer-Rounds amendment to the FY2024 NDAA, explicitly modeled on the JFK Assassination Records Collection Act, would have created an independent, presidentially appointed nine-member UAP Records Review Board with subpoena power and a presumption of disclosure, and would have had the federal government "exercise eminent domain over any and all recovered technologies of unknown origin and biological evidence of non-human intelligence." Schumer told the Senate floor the government "has refused to share" UAP information and that he had been "notified by multiple credible sources that information on UAPs has...been withheld from Congress, which if true is a violation of laws." The very premise — that an *independent* outside body with eminent domain was necessary — is itself an implicit congressional judgment that existing mechanisms, including AARO, were inadequate.

The watered-down final bill and Pentagon lobbying. [STRONG] The NDAA conference stripped both the Review Board and the eminent-domain provisions; Rounds said the omissions meant UAP information would remain "hidden from Congress and the American people" and "we are lacking oversight opportunities...and we are not fulfilling our responsibilities." Reporting (Douglas Johnson, summarized in the Roswell Daily Record) found that

OUSD(I&S) provided congressional negotiators a "33-page line-by-line rewrite" weakening — but not eliminating — the eminent-domain provision in November 2023. This is pointed: Kirkpatrick simultaneously insisted no such recoverable materials existed in commercial industry, raising the question of why the Pentagon fought to weaken a confiscation provision over allegedly nonexistent material.

GAO review and the Senate Intelligence Committee's distrust. [STRONG] The Intelligence Authorization Act for FY2025 (S. 4443, reported by the Senate Select Committee on Intelligence June 3, 2024, after a unanimous 17–0 committee vote) contained a Title X on UAP including a mandated Government Accountability Office review of AARO (Sec. 1001) and a provision (Sec. 1003) to prohibit funding for any UAP activity "protected under any form of special access or restricted access limitations" not formally reported to the AARO Director and congressional leadership. The IAA was enacted as Division F of the FY2025 NDAA (P.L. 118-159, signed Dec. 23, 2024); the GAO-review mandate and controlled-access-program reforms were enacted, while the broadest Sec. 1003 funding cutoff appears to have been narrowed or dropped in conference (a pattern mirroring the prior year). Sen. Mike Rounds said the bill "increases transparency on UAP-related

government programs by requiring further reporting of all activity involving UAPs protected under special or restricted access." [U.S. Senate](#) Sen. Marco Rubio (then SSCI Vice Chairman) said serious officials with "firsthand knowledge or firsthand claims" of UFO retrieval and reverse-engineering had come to Congress, asking "what incentive would so many people with that kind of qualification...have to come forward and make something up?" Sen. Kirsten Gillibrand, asked in May 2024 whether AARO's report closed the matter, replied: "Oh, it's definitely not case closed... the two whistleblowers that I've met with did not meet with AARO and refused to meet with AARO. And so maybe the next director they'll meet with, but I can't assess them unless AARO can talk to them." A mandated GAO audit of an office is itself a strong institutional signal of low confidence.

5. Counterpoints (for honesty and balance)

- **AARO's process defenses. [STRONG]** AARO states it "created a secure process in partnership with the highest-level security officials within the DoD, IC, and other organizations" and "was granted full, unrestricted access by all organizations." The FOIA record genuinely shows repeated, documented, good-faith invitations to Grusch with formal authorization memos —

undercutting the simplest "AARO refused to talk to witnesses" narrative.

- **Real transparency steps. [STRONG]** AARO launched a public reporting portal and case-resolution releases, declassified and published the Kona Blue documents, partnered with the National Archives on Blue Book records, and convened an August 2025 civilian-research data workshop. The historical report is openly hedged about cases it could not resolve. Under Kosloski, AARO acknowledged hundreds of "uncharacterized and unattributed" cases that "appear to have demonstrated unusual flight characteristics."
- **The honeypot theory is structurally near-unfalsifiable. [MODERATE]** If AARO finds nothing, that is read as "containment"; had it found something, it would be a "limited hangout." This makes the thesis difficult to disprove and warrants caution. Notably, several of AARO's sharpest critics (Mellon, and aviation-defense writer Tyler Rogoway) are themselves *skeptical* of the extraterrestrial hypothesis while faulting AARO's rigor — meaning "AARO is incompetent / conflicted" does not logically require "AARO is hiding aliens."
- **Some critic claims rest on weak sourcing. [WEAK]** Change.org petitions, interpretations of leaked

Signal messages, and many UFO-enthusiast outlets carry far less evidentiary weight than congressional testimony, FOIA documents, and named-official statements, and should not be treated as established fact.

Recommendations

1. **Weight the structural and procedural critiques as well-established.** The conflict of interest (AARO inside OUSD(I&S)), the thin ~30-interview methodology, the documented factual errors, the absence of DNI endorsement, and demonstrated congressional distrust are all anchored in primary sources. This is where the adversarial case is strongest and should be presented with confidence.
2. **Treat the deliberate "honeypot / disinformation vehicle" thesis as plausible-but-unproven.** It is supported by genuine historical precedent (Robertson Panel, Condon Report) and process irregularities, but not by direct evidence of intent; present it as a reasoned hypothesis, explicitly flagging its near-unfalsifiable structure.
3. **Use AARO's Historical Record Report Volume II as the decisive near-term test.** If it engages named witnesses with primary-source adjudication of their specific claims and

documents its methodology, that materially upgrades AARO's credibility. If it repeats the "circular reporting from a consistent group" framing without engaging named witnesses, that strengthens the containment thesis. This test requires no classified access to evaluate.

4. **Track the statutorily mandated GAO review of AARO.** An independent watchdog finding is the most authoritative available path to resolving the capture question; treat its publication as a key milestone.
5. **Benchmark that would change the assessment:** If an *independent* body — a congressional select committee or presidentially appointed review board with subpoena power and genuine SAP read-in access — reached the same "no evidence" conclusion AARO did, the capture/conflict critique would be substantially undercut. Conversely, any documented instance of a SAP or contractor refusing AARO access to UAP-tagged material would convert the "cannot compel access" inference from [MODERATE] to [STRONG].

Caveats

- **"Resolved" vs. "explained":** AARO frequently states unsolved cases *could* be resolved "if additional, quality data were available." Critics

reasonably call this defining the problem away rather than solving it; the office's own reports still concede large numbers of uncharacterized cases.

- **The Grusch dispute is a real, two-sided factual conflict.** Both AARO (FOIA invitation records) and Grusch (unanswered security concerns; ICIG-only material) have documentary support. Neither side's account should be presented as settled.
- **Source-agenda transparency:** Much of the pro-disclosure commentary cited here comes from advocates — Marik von Rennenkampff (a Sol Foundation contributor), Christopher Mellon (chairman of the UAP Disclosure Fund board), and the New Paradigm Institute. Their direct quotations and bill-text citations are reliable; their interpretive framing ("the Pentagon is lying") is not neutral and is labeled accordingly.
- **Recency hazard:** Some 2026-dated UFO-news items circulating online (e.g., a "PURSUE" disclosure portal, a White House-tasked Avi Loeb "UAP Science Advisory Council," claimed imminent video releases) originate from low-quality aggregators and unverified single-source reporting; they are not relied upon for any core finding in this brief and should be treated with caution pending primary-source confirmation.
- **Bottom line:** The defensible verdict is that AARO is **demonstrably conflicted and, on the evidence**

of its own flagship report, methodologically weak

— a finding strong enough that Congress mandated an independent GAO audit of it. Whether that reflects ordinary bureaucratic incompetence and institutional self-protection (well-evidenced) or a deliberate disinformation/limited-hangout operation (plausible, precedented, but unproven) is the line the available evidence does not let us cross with confidence.